

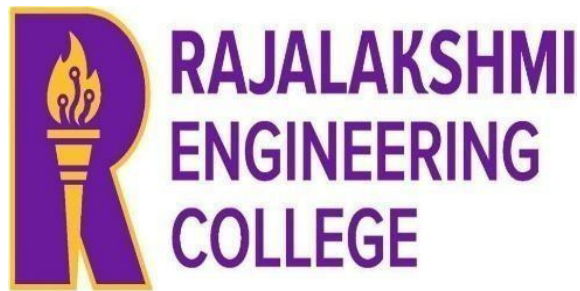
**FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING CD23731
REPORT**

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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this report titled “THE EXCUSE” is the Bonafide work of V.J.LAKSHNAN (231701030) who carried out the work under my supervision. Certified further that to the best of my knowledge the work reported herein does not form part of any other thesis or dissertation on the basis of which a degree or award was conferred on an earlier occasion on this or any other candidate.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Film making is a creative form of visual communication that combines storytelling, acting, cinematography, sound, lighting and editing to communicate an idea or experience to an audience. A short film presents a complete story within a limited duration, making it important to develop a clear concept and use every scene effectively. Radio podcasting, on the other hand, communicates stories through audio elements such as narration, dialogue, music, sound effects and silence. Both forms require creativity, planning and effective storytelling.

The project titled “The Excuse” is a short psychological drama of approximately five minutes, developed as part of the Film Making and Radio Podcasting (CD23731) course. The story follows a group of friends who, on the night before, make a firm pact to meet at 6:00 AM the next morning for a jog at the park. When the alarm rings, however, only one of them is ready to keep the promise. The others remain trapped in the glow of their smartphone screens, exhausted from late-night screen time and armed with a familiar wall of excuses.

The film uses an everyday, deeply relatable situation — the gap between what we intend at night and what we do in the morning — to explore procrastination, screen fatigue and the illusion of waiting for motivation. The tension is resolved not through a twist of events but through a quiet realisation: once the friends finally step out and begin to jog, they discover that the hardest part was never the run itself, but getting out of bed and starting. The story is designed to be reflective and motivational while still following the structure of a well-built short film, and it lends itself naturally to being retold as an audio-only radio podcast.

CHAPTER 2

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The main idea of “The Excuse” is to show that motivation does not come before action — it comes after it. The film opens in a warm, ordinary setting: friends sitting together at night, talking about fitness and self-improvement. This familiar beginning helps the audience recognise the situation as one they may have lived through themselves, making promises at night that feel easy to keep.

As the film moves into the 6:00 AM bedroom, the mood shifts sharply. The lighting turns cold and blue, the alarm becomes irritating, and the friends sink into mindless scrolling and snooze buttons. The motivated friend calls the others and meets resistance in the form of classic rationalisations — “five more minutes”, “we’re exhausted from yesterday”, “we’ll start from Monday”. The eventual decision to get up, put on their shoes and reach the park delivers the emotional turning point of the film.

The film uses a small number of locations — bedrooms or a living space, a neighbourhood street and a public park track — with three friends and a handful of everyday props such as smartphones, an alarm, running shoes and a park bench. This keeps the production simple while still allowing camera work, colour, editing and sound to be used deliberately to express the contrast between inertia and action.

CHAPTER 3

TITLE – THE EXCUSE

The title “The Excuse” refers directly to the central conflict of the story. The real obstacle in the film is not physical effort, weather, distance or time. It is the small, comfortable lie that a person tells themselves to avoid starting — the excuse. The film draws its meaning from how ordinary and believable these excuses sound, and how easily they are accepted when they come from ourselves.

The title also carries a quiet irony that becomes clear at the end. The friends spend the early part of the film convinced that they are too tired to run, yet after only a short distance on the park track they feel energised and relieved. The excuse, it turns out, was the only thing that had been holding them back. In this way, “The Excuse” works both as a literal description of the dialogue in the film and as a comment on how procrastination disguises itself as a reasonable decision.

CHAPTER 4

GENRE

The film belongs to the psychological drama genre, with strong elements of slice-of-life and motivational storytelling. The drama comes from an internal struggle that almost every student and young professional understands — the conflict between discipline and comfort. Unlike an action-driven story, the conflict here takes place inside the characters’ minds and is expressed through their body language, their dialogue and the atmosphere of the room.

The slice-of-life element comes from the realistic setting and everyday behaviour: late-night phone use, hitting snooze, and making promises for “from Monday”. The motivational element emerges in the closing scenes, where the friends discover the reward of taking action and the film ends with a direct message to the audience.

The major dramatic elements used in the film are:

- The contrast between a confident promise at night and reluctance in the morning
- Screen fatigue and the pull of the smartphone
- A wall of familiar, relatable excuses
- Social accountability — one friend refusing to let the pact break
- A visual shift from cold and dark to warm and bright
- A reflective epiphany followed by a direct closing message

CHAPTER 5

OBJECTIVES

The main objective of the project is to create an engaging and meaningful short film using a simple production setup and everyday, relatable events. The project also aims to demonstrate how colour, camera work, sound and editing can be combined to express an internal emotional journey rather than only an external plot.

The specific objectives are:

- To develop an original short-film story with a clear message.
- To understand screenplay writing and scene-by-scene structure.
- To use colour and lighting as visual metaphors for emotional states.
- To practise camera framing and movement that reflect a character's energy.
- To use sound design and silence to support tension and release.
- To develop basic video editing, transitions and continuity skills.
- To understand the role of background music in a motivational drama.
- To adapt the story into a radio podcast format.
- To understand how visual storytelling differs from audio storytelling.

CHAPTER 6

STORY DEVELOPMENT

The story was developed around a situation that almost every student has experienced in some form — making an ambitious plan the night before and failing to act on it the next morning. The idea was kept deliberately simple so that the emotional impact could come from performance, atmosphere and contrast rather than from a complicated plot.

The first part of the story establishes the friends in a warm, relaxed setting, sharing goals and shaking hands on a promise. This opening was written to feel sincere, so that the later failure to follow through feels human rather than careless.

The middle section was developed to build friction gradually — first the irritating alarm and the cold glow of the phone screens, then the phone call in which the motivated friend tries to pull the others out of bed, and finally the wall of excuses that keeps them there. The story then turns with the decision to get up and go. The final section shows the reward of that decision: movement becoming rhythmic, sunlight breaking through the trees, and a shared realisation that the hardest step was simply starting.

CHAPTER 7

STORY SYNOPSIS

The story begins at night, as a group of friends sit together and talk about self-improvement and their fitness goals. They are enthusiastic and sincere. Before the night ends they make a firm pact to meet at 6:00 AM the next morning for a jog at the park, sealing the promise with handshakes and verbal agreements. The scene fades into quiet night ambience.

The film then cuts to a darkened bedroom at 6:00 AM. A smartphone alarm rings, its screen showing the time. The bed is lit only by the cold, harsh light of the phone. Two of the friends, worn out by late-night screen time, hit snooze or scroll mindlessly instead of getting up. The repetitive alarm chime and the tired faces lit from below make the comfort of the bed feel like a trap.

The motivated friend, already awake and ready, calls the others. “Bro, it’s 6:00 AM, let’s go to the park!” he says. The replies come slowly and predictably: five more minutes, exhausted from yesterday, we’ll start from Monday. Every excuse sounds reasonable on its own, but together they form a wall between the friends and the promise they made the night before. The friend refuses to give up and keeps encouraging the others despite the resistance.

Eventually, the hesitation breaks. The scene transitions from the dim bedroom to the bright outdoor park, with sunlight breaking through the trees. The friends reluctantly gather at the park entrance, put on their shoes and begin to jog along the track. At first their movement is sluggish and forced; gradually it becomes steady and rhythmic as their bodies warm up and the morning opens around them.

After the run, the three friends sit on a park bench and on the grass under the morning sun, catching their breath, sweating and visibly relieved. They talk casually and realise that the hardest barrier was not the run itself, but getting out of bed and starting. Their heavy breathing settles into the peaceful sounds of birdsong and the park.

The film closes on the three friends on a bench, looking out ahead. A message appears on screen: “Don’t wait for motivation. Take the first step. Start first. Motivation will follow.” The credits and special thanks follow as an uplifting ambient pad rises and the film fades to black.

CHAPTER 8

CHARACTERS

The first character is the Protagonist, who is also the Motivator of the group. He wakes up at 6:00 AM, prepared to keep the pact made the night before. He is disciplined without being preachy, and he keeps calling and encouraging his friends despite their excuses. His persistence drives the narrative forward, and it is his initiative that ultimately helps the group overcome hesitation.

The second and third characters are the two Hesitant Friends. They are likeable and sincere, and they genuinely intended to keep the promise. However, they are trapped in late-night screen time and morning fatigue, and they use excuses to avoid physical activity. They represent the everyday struggle with procrastination that the audience will recognise in themselves. Their eventual decision to give in and step outside is what gives the film its warmth and its message.

The film's credits acknowledge the support of Sanjeeve R.V., Harish Babu, R.V. Supreet and Derick Dilip, to whom special thanks are given in the closing titles. The film was written and directed by V J Lakshnan.

CHAPTER 9

SCENE DEVELOPMENT

9.1 Scene 1 – Night Before: The Pact and the Intent

The film opens at night, in a gathering or bedroom chat setting. The friends sit together discussing self-improvement and fitness goals, and they make a firm pact to meet at 6:00 AM the next morning for a jog at the park. Handshakes and verbal agreements reinforce their collective commitment. Warm indoor lighting is used, and the conversational audio fades into night ambient sound.

9.2 Scene 2 – 6:00 AM: The Friction and the Bed Trap

The setting changes to a darkened bedroom at 6:00 AM. An alarm rings on a smartphone screen showing 6:00 AM, and the bed is lit only by the cold, harsh light of the screen. The friends hit snooze or scroll mindlessly, overwhelmed by late-night fatigue and reluctance. A low-angle close-up of the phone screen illuminating tired faces is used, along with a repetitive, irritating alarm chime.

9.3 Scene 3 – The Call and the Wall of Excuses

The scene uses a split perspective between the bedroom and the outside or hallway. The motivated friend calls the others, trying to get them out of bed: “Bro, it’s 6:00 AM, let’s go to the park!” The friends answer with “Five more minutes da... exhausted from yesterday... we’ll start from Monday.” One friend attempts to motivate the rest while meeting resistance, rationalisations and classic procrastination excuses. The tone is one of high tension between discipline and comfort-zone resistance.

9.4 Scene 4 – Breaking the Resistance and Arriving at the Park

The setting transitions from the dim bedroom to the bright outdoor park, with sunlight breaking through the trees. The group reluctantly gathers at the park entry. Pushing past their initial hesitation, the friends put on their shoes and begin jogging along the park track. A tracking shot follows the group as their movement shifts from sluggish and forced to steady and rhythmic.

9.5 Scene 5 – Post-Workout Reflection: The Epiphany

The three friends sit together on a park bench and on the grassy lawn under the morning sunlight, catching their breath, sweating and visibly relieved. They converse casually, recognising that the hardest barrier was not the physical run itself but getting out of bed and starting. The heavy breathing on the soundtrack settles into peaceful morning birdsong and park atmosphere.

9.6 Scene 6 – Resolution and Closing Messages

The final scene is framed on a park bench with the three friends looking out ahead. The closing text overlay reads: “Don’t wait for motivation. Take the first step. Start first. Motivation will follow.” The credits then appear — “A Film by V J Lakshnan” and “Special Thanks to Sanjeeve R.V., Harish Babu, R.V. Supreet, and Derick Dilip” — while an uplifting ambient audio pad rises and the text fades out to black.

CHAPTER 10

CLIMAX AND ENDING

The climax of the film occurs at the moment of decision — when the friends finally push past their hesitation, put on their shoes and step out towards the park. It is a quiet climax rather than a loud one, because the conflict in the story is internal. The victory is not against another person but against inertia and the comfort of the bed.

The emotional resolution follows in the post-workout scene, where the friends recognise that the run itself was not the difficult part. This epiphany gives the film its central insight: the barrier was never physical, it was only the first step.

The ending is a calm, reflective moment with the three friends looking out ahead from the park bench, followed by the closing message on screen. The audience is left with a direct, motivational thought rather than a complicated conclusion, mirroring real life, where the reward of action is often simpler and more satisfying than the reluctance that came before it.

CHAPTER 11

CINEMATOGRAPHY

Cinematography in “The Excuse” is used to mirror the emotional rhythm of the story. The opening night scene uses steady, comfortable shots that establish warmth and companionship. In the 6:00 AM bedroom, the camera becomes more confined and intimate, using a low-angle close-up of the phone screen illuminating tired faces to show how the device traps its users.

The phone call sequence uses a split perspective between the bedroom and the outside or hallway, allowing the audience to see both the motivated friend and the resisting friends and to feel the tension between them. The transition to the park is marked by a shift to open, bright framing, with sunlight breaking through the trees.

A tracking shot is used to follow the group as they jog along the park track. The camera keeps pace with the characters, and their movement changes from sluggish and forced to steady and rhythmic, showing the shift in their energy visually. The final scenes use calmer, wider shots of the friends resting on the bench, ending with a framing of the three looking out ahead as the closing titles appear.

CHAPTER 12

LIGHTING

Lighting is one of the most important storytelling tools in “The Excuse”, because it is used as a visual metaphor. The film is built on a clear contrast between two colour palettes.

- Cold Blue and Dark Tones (6:00 AM Bedroom): These represent resistance, fatigue, inertia and the comfort zone. The bed is lit only by the cold, harsh light of a smartphone screen, which makes the room feel heavy and the friends look drained.
- Warm Golden Morning Light (Park Scene): This represents clarity, energy, accomplishment and action. Sunlight breaking through the trees gives the park scenes a hopeful, open quality.

The opening night scene uses warm indoor lighting to show sincerity and friendship before the cold tones of the morning take over. The shift from the dim bedroom to the bright outdoor park reinforces the emotional release of the story — moving from a closed, tired space into the open air, and from excuse to action.

CHAPTER 13

SOUND DESIGN

Sound plays a key role in expressing the emotional journey of “The Excuse”. The night scene begins with natural conversational audio that fades into soft night ambience. In the morning bedroom, the sound design becomes deliberately irritating, using a piercing alarm chime and repeated snooze sounds to communicate discomfort and reluctance.

During the excuse-making sequence, the acoustics of the room are muffled and indoor-sounding, which increases the sense of confinement. The transition to the park is marked by a sudden change to crisp outdoor environmental audio — birds, wind and footsteps on gravel — which makes the change of atmosphere feel like a breath of fresh air.

After the jog, the heavy breathing of the characters gradually settles into peaceful morning birdsong. The film closes with an uplifting ambient audio pad that rises as the closing text fades to black.

Important sound elements include:

- Piercing alarm chimes and snooze sounds
- Muffled indoor acoustics during the excuse-making sequence
- Phone notification and scrolling sounds
- Crisp outdoor ambience: birds, wind and footsteps on gravel
- Heavy breathing settling into calm
- An uplifting ambient pad for the closing message

CHAPTER 14

EDITING TECHNIQUES

Editing in “The Excuse” is used to control the pace of the story and to make the emotional shift from inertia to action felt by the audience. The night scene uses longer, relaxed cuts to establish the friendly atmosphere. The 6:00 AM bedroom sequence uses repeated alarm-and-snooze beats to create a feeling of being stuck in a loop.

The phone call uses cuts between the motivated friend and the friends in bed, so that the dialogue and the excuses feel like a real back-and-forth conversation. The transition from the dim bedroom to the bright outdoor park is the key cut of the film — the sudden change of colour, light and sound emphasises the difference between resistance and action.

During the jog, the editing follows the rhythm of the characters’ movement, moving from uncertain, slower cuts to a steadier flow as they settle into their pace. The post-workout scene is edited with calm, unhurried cuts, and the closing titles fade out to black to give the message time to settle.

CHAPTER 15

USE OF PROPS AND LOCATION

The project is designed to be produced using easily accessible locations, which keeps the production simple while allowing for a variety of shots and moods. The key locations are:

- Bedrooms or living space (night pact and 6:00 AM scenes)
- Neighbourhood street (transition to the park)
- Public park track, bench and lawn (jogging, reflection and closing scenes)

The major props required are:

- Smartphones
- Alarm clock
- Running shoes
- Park bench

The small number of props keeps the focus on the performances and the emotional contrast between the cold, dark bedroom and the warm, bright park rather than on production complexity. The smartphone is the most important prop of all, since it represents the distraction and screen fatigue that keep the friends in bed.

CHAPTER 16

RADIO PODCAST ADAPTATION

The same story can be adapted into a radio podcast by replacing visual storytelling with audio cues and dialogue. In the film, the audience sees the cold blue phone light in the dark bedroom and the warm golden sunlight in the park; in the podcast, this contrast must be communicated through sound alone — the muffled, closed-in acoustics of the room versus the open, crisp ambience of the park.

The visual metaphor of colour cannot be shown in audio form, so it is replaced by sound design. The alarm chime, the snooze sound and the muffled indoor acoustics represent the “cold” inertia of the morning, while birdsong, wind and footsteps on gravel represent the “warm” energy of action. The shift of scenes is signalled by a change in ambience, allowing the listener to feel the transition without seeing it.

The closing text overlay of the film, “Don’t wait for motivation. Take the first step. Start first. Motivation will follow.”, becomes a spoken line in the podcast, delivered over the rising ambient pad. This demonstrates how a visual message must be redesigned for the podcast medium to work.

CHAPTER 17

RADIO PODCAST SCRIPT APPROACH

The podcast version can open with soft night ambience and the warm sound of friends talking, as they make their pact to meet at 6:00 AM. A handshake and a short, cheerful agreement can close the scene before the ambience fades.

The second scene begins with the piercing alarm chime and the sound of the snooze button being pressed repeatedly. A short narrated description of the setting — a dark bedroom at 6:00 AM — can be used to help the listener picture the cold light of the phone screens. The sound of scrolling and muffled acoustics can convey the trap of the bed.

The phone call sequence relies entirely on dialogue. The motivated friend's lines should be clear and energetic, while the friends' replies — "Five more minutes da... exhausted from yesterday... we'll start from Monday" — should be slow and drowsy. The transition to the park is marked by a sudden shift to crisp outdoor sounds: birds, wind and footsteps on gravel.

The jogging sequence can use rhythmic footsteps that begin uneven and gradually become steady, mirroring the visual change in the film. The reflective conversation on the bench is supported by heavy breathing settling into birdsong, and the podcast ends with the closing message spoken over a rising ambient pad, followed by the credits.

CHAPTER 18

VOICE AND AUDIO PERFORMANCE

Voice acting carries the entire emotional tone of the podcast version, since the audience cannot see facial expressions or lighting. The motivated friend's voice should be warm, awake and persistent, with encouragement that never becomes harsh or preachy. The hesitant friends' voices should be low, slow and drowsy at the start, then gradually brighten as they move and their energy returns.

The contrast between the two energies should be maintained throughout the excuse-making scene so that the shift at the park is clearly audible. By the reflective bench scene, the voices of all three friends should sound relaxed and relieved, with a natural tone of quiet realisation rather than a lecture.

The following elements are important:

- Distinct vocal contrast between the motivator and the hesitant friends
- Drowsy, believable delivery of the excuses
- A natural shift in energy from fatigue to freshness
- Sound effects and ambience that separate the bedroom from the park
- Light background music to support the emotional shift
- Effective use of silence before the closing message

CHAPTER 19

PRODUCTION PROCESS

The production of the project can be divided into three stages: pre-production, production and post-production.

During pre-production, the idea was developed into a simple screenplay and shot-by-shot breakdown. The three characters, the locations (bedroom or living space, neighbourhood street and public park) and the small prop list were finalised. The colour contrast between the cold, dark bedroom and the warm, golden park was planned in advance, along with the key lines of dialogue and the closing message.

During production, the night scene, the 6:00 AM bedroom sequence and the phone call were recorded first, followed by the outdoor scenes at the park, including the jogging shots and the post-workout reflection. Shooting the outdoor scenes in the morning sunlight allowed the warm, golden tones planned for the park scenes to be captured naturally.

During post-production, the footage was reviewed and cut together, with particular attention paid to the transition from the dim bedroom to the bright park. Sound effects such as the alarm chime, muffled indoor acoustics and outdoor ambience were added, along with the closing text overlays, the credits and the rising ambient pad, before the final video was exported.

CHAPTER 20

CHALLENGES FACED

One of the main challenges in producing a film driven by mood is making the contrast between the two halves of the story feel convincing. The performances of the hesitant friends needed to look genuinely tired and reluctant without becoming exaggerated, so that the excuses would sound natural and relatable.

Working with natural light was another challenge. The cold, blue tones of the bedroom and the warm, golden light of the park depend heavily on the time of day and the quality of the available light, so the scenes had to be planned and shot carefully to keep the colour palette consistent.

Keeping the film within about five minutes while still giving each scene room to breathe also required careful trimming in editing, so that the message would remain clear without the story feeling rushed or repetitive.

CHAPTER 21

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Through this project, several practical skills were developed, including screenplay writing, scene planning, camera operation, acting, sound recording and video editing.

The project also demonstrated how powerful colour, light and sound can be as storytelling tools. Using cold blue tones against warm golden light, and muffled indoor acoustics against crisp outdoor ambience, showed how a simple contrast can express an entire emotional journey without a single line of explanation.

The radio podcast adaptation provided additional experience in voice acting and audio editing, and highlighted how visual metaphors must be reimagined as sound cues and spoken lines in order to work for a listening audience.

CHAPTER 22

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The final outcome of the project is a short psychological drama titled “The Excuse”, supported by a radio podcast adaptation of the same story. The film is expected to engage the audience through a relatable, everyday struggle with procrastination that is resolved by the simple act of taking the first step.

The project demonstrates the practical use of visual storytelling, colour symbolism, sound design and editing rhythm, while its student-life setting and clear, motivational message are intended to make it easy for a college audience to connect with. Viewers are expected to leave with a small but memorable thought: that action creates motivation, not the other way around.

CHAPTER 23

CONCLUSION

The project “The Excuse” demonstrates how a small, everyday moment — an alarm ringing at 6:00 AM — can be developed into a meaningful short film through careful use of colour, sound, performance and editing. The story begins with a sincere pact made at night and builds through fatigue, screen distraction and excuses, before resolving in the simple act of getting up and starting.

The project combines screenplay writing, cinematography, lighting, sound design and editing, with each element working together to express the contrast between inertia and action. The use of a small cast, simple locations and everyday props also shows that an effective film does not require elaborate production resources.

The radio podcast adaptation further demonstrates how a visual story must be reshaped for an audio-only medium, replacing colour and framing with ambience, sound effects, pacing and vocal performance.

Overall, “The Excuse” provides practical experience in both film making and radio podcasting while conveying a message that is easy to remember and easy to apply.

“Don’t wait for motivation. Take the first step. Start first. Motivation will follow.”